„‘nother nightmare, Buck?“ Steve asked, his voice slow and sleepy.

“Kinda. Not like the ones about Zola. It was weird, I don’t know- I went somewhere, I think? And you weren’t there,” Bucky replied while carding his fingers through his short, mussed hair.

“Then why’d you go there?”

“It just happened, I- I can’t explain it. I didn’t really choose to.”

For a moment, they looked at each other in the dark, their cots barely two feet apart. Bucky was still sitting up from where he had jolted awake earlier, breathing hard and trembling ever so slightly.

“Sounds an awful lot like falling asleep, Bucky. Is that where you went, to sleep? Because you should go back there before we find out what the colonel has planned for our sorry asses tomorrow,” Steve yawned.

“I don’t know.” The turmoil in Bucky’s insides had barely calmed down, but he lied back down and frowned at the tent. With a sigh, Steve got up and shooed Bucky to lie on the edge of the cot before wrapping himself with his big arms and thousand kilowatts radiator torso around Bucky.

“See? You couldn’t get away from me if you tried. Now let me get some shuteye, jerk.”

“Punk,” Bucky mumbled with a smile. Finally, his heart rate slowed down to something close to normal as he breathed in the familiar scent of his friend. He had been glad to discover that, at least, that hadn’t changed with the serum.

It was a good way to fall asleep and a good way to wake up the next morning; groaning in the face of another exhausting day, sure, but by each other’s side.

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He’d had the dream before, he thought.

He felt alone and hollow despite the crushing pressure on his back and stomach. It was as if he was caught between two infinitely dark planes of glass, squeezing him to the point he thought he wouldn’t be able to breathe much longer. Slightly panicked, he started to move, tried to push his body forward, tried to get somewhere. Little by little, he made way as the temperature around him dropped and a sense of dread started to envelop him.

I’m going to die, his own voice echoed through his head, I’m going to die and I won’t even know what happened.

But then he suddenly fell, the feeling of it stretching into eternity even as he landed face-forward after just the fraction of a second.

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“You alright?” Bucky heard a familiar voice ask.

“Sure, breathing in grass and dirt is one of my hobbies, didn’t you know?” he responded while finally managing to turn over and stare into the cold, grey sky, framed by point tree tops.

“I didn’t know that nor should I have to – and you’d better show some respect for your superiors, soldier,” the man with the bright blue eyes, now narrowed with indignation, said.

“Very funny, Stevie,” Bucky grumbled, purposefully using the nickname his friend hated as he hoisted himself up into something akin to sitting.

“Excuse me?”

“What, you loose the hearing in your left ear again? Erskine really should have left a detailed information sheet for the serum behind,” Bucky tried for humor once again and stood up.

“Now you listen closely, pal, I won’t stand for you talking about a dead man like that,” the Captain hissed between gritted teeth as he walked up to Bucky, his broad frame towering over him despite the few inches that seperated them in height. With a confused frown, Bucky took a step back and scrubed his left hand over his face as the man continued talking. “How do you know about my ears, anyways? I thought the army doesn’t dole out private health information to every Tom, Dick and Harry who’s too invested in a stranger’s business.”

“Did you just call me a stranger, you dumbass? What the fuck?” Bucky yelled incredulously and threw his hands in the air just as a fist as hard as steel connected with his jaw.

“I won’t have a nobody insult me to my face like that,” the man in front of him proclaimed, his arms still raised in a fighting stance.

Steve had never hit Bucky and so Bucky reacted the only way he had learned to respond to someone throwing punches they had no business throwing. He swung his right arm, easily dodged by the blond man who gave him an unimpressed look just in time to have his left knee kicked out from under him. The man caught himself before falling down, now viciously angry as he lept up to punch Bucky in the stomach, knocking him back a few feet. While Bucky was still catching his breath, the Captain advanced in his direction and

kicked higher than he should have because Bucky grabbed at his ankle, wrenching him to the ground.

And it was there that it hit Bucky: This wasn't Steve. It couldn't be. There was something missing from the man's face: A softness to his hard edges, a yielding quality no one ever noticed because of the stubbornness that made up so much of Steve's being, but Bucky knew him better than that. He'd seen Steve sick to the brink of death and beaten to a pulp, more determined to survive and stand for what he thought was right, but never without a little bit of tenderness that lit up his features, a fondness when he rolled his eyes and a hint of a smile that crinkled around his eyes more often than not when Bucky looked at him. And this man had none of that, his face as unforgiving as the punch to the femur with which he managed to bring Bucky to his knees.

All the fight left Bucky's body as he slumped together on the dirt, the man surprised but quick to restrain his arms before taking a second to consider him.

"Who are you?" he finally asked, earning himself a mirthless chuckle from a completely defeated Bucky.

"I'm Bucky," he tried one last time, hoping against all odds.

"Who the hell is Bucky?"

With a sigh, Bucky let his head loll forward.

"Sergeant James Buchanan Barnes, 107th, at your service." Bucky would have added a lazy salute if not for the strong hands holding his wrists together behind his back and so he just shrugged instead, still not looking at the not-quite-Steve next to him. Silence ensued, thick and heavy in Bucky's lungs.

"We'll get you to the Colonel, see what he makes of you," the man finally murmured, gruffly pulling Bucky to his feet and shoving him in the direction of the camp.

"Rogers. Here to bother me with something I don't care about again, I'm sure," the Colonel received them with his back turned to Bucky as well as the man still tightly gripping his forearms.

"Sir, I believe this might be a spy."

"A spy? And you thought it best to bring him to the place where all the vital information is lying around?" he replied dryly and unimpressed as ever as he put down a stack of papers in front of him and walked around the table to face the two.

The man with Steve's face might not have been the same as the Steve Rogers Bucky'd known all his life, but Philips sure seemed exactly as Bucky remembered him.

"Sir, he knew my name when he ambushed me in the forest."

“Ambushed?” Bucky thought and Philips asked. “The bruise and the scratches are his work, then,” the Colonel remarked while pointing at the Captain’s face.

“Yessir.”

“A spy would do his best to blend in, not sock Captain America in the jaw. What brings you here, then?” Philips turned to Bucky.

“I don’t know, I woke up on the floor and St- the Captain was there. I thought I knew him, but-“

“Okay, let’s speed this up. Normally I’d send you to the next psychiatric facility because you’re not making any sense and I don’t intend to make any for you. But I’ve been scrambling to find a training partner for Rogers and you seem to have handled yourself just fine.”

“Sir-“ the Captains started to protest.

“Rogers, if you think this was a question, it’s not. You need to stay in form between missions and if he’s of any use for that, we’ll take it.”

“But if he’s-“

“Yeah, yeah, we’ll make Meyers give him the third degree. If he says he’s fine, you’ll be training with him.”

“Yessir,” the Captain hissed through his teeth, obviously furious at the turn of events.

“Welcome to the madness, son. Just know that if you end up in my tent again, it’s because you’ve screwed up.” Philips directed a glance in Bucky’s direction before picking up a folder on his table. All Bucky could do is nod and follow the other man outside.

The first night was the worst – then again, every night was the worst, in a way.

But the first time he was about to fall asleep, he still had hope. There was something in him, burning fierce and bright that made him believe it might all be okay tomorrow. He’d wake up in a cot next to Steve, his Steve, not the man who had been pushing him around all day, and he’d tell him all about that weird dream he had.

They’d laugh, Steve would pat him on the back and maybe even pull him into one of those bonecrushing hugs Bucky had grown to love so much. Even when Steve was skinny and short and not able to lift a crate full of tools, you’d have never known it from the way he’d wrap his arms around a person, strong and sure and warm. Most people didn’t have the chance to find out, either, but Bucky had been on the receiving end of Steve’s reassuring hugs since before they were learning the alphabet.

It was to these kinds of memories Bucky fell asleep to.

In the early hours of the morning, something tugged at his consciousness, a frantic fear creeping up his spine. With a jolt, he sat up, looking around to find himself alone. Then he remembered – there was no Steve, not here, but there was a man who looked just like him and, the more time Bucky spent with him, nothing like him at all.

At first, Bucky tried to fight it, thinking of his own life so hard he surely must be back to it when he woke up – to no avail. Then came the numbness, spreading faster through his whole body with each day he realized he was still not back home. This must be hell, Bucky thought, the one Steve would sometimes cry about being afraid of when they were around thirteen. The memory brought Bucky close to tears while his limbs weighed a thousand pounds and his head hurt with a dull, throbbing pain.

With time, it got easier, a little less heavy, a bit more bearable. After a few months, he only needed a few breaths to come to terms with it in the mornings, not the two hours he'd spent frozen in place in the beginning. Having a purpose helped and even if he didn't like this Captain America who obeyed his superiors when they told him he was too valuable for a particular mission, he was glad to be a part of the effort to defeat the Nazis.

Even the Captain started to grow on him a little bit – Bucky had started to call him Steven, unwilling to let *his* Steve go, whereever he was. Steven wasn't much of a laugh, unwilling to join in on any joke. But he was a good fighter, strong-willed and surprisingly graceful at times, impressively efficient in a way that showed not just his enhanced physical abilities, but his sharp sense of when to strike a blow or kick someone's legs out from under them.

Some evenings, they played cards together, silent and focussed and Bucky was almost content for a minute or two before his guts twisted at the sight of those familiar features someone else wore so well.

Then he got sent back home, found a job and a shoebox to live in without any papers, made a friend or two, although it never lasted very long.

In the end, they all either moved away or worked second and third jobs or started families and Bucky couldn't bring himself to mourn the loss all that much.

He was still so busy missing what he had lost in that moment when he woke up in a forest, with Steven standing over him.

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It felt like being crushed. Dark planes of glass, his body trapped between them – he'd been here before. Scrambled thoughts rushed to the surface of Bucky's barely conscious mind and he started to breathe quicker.

He knew this. This was- a chance, maybe? But then again, he'd spent the better part of the last few years trying to stamp out any hope flickering in his chest in an effort not to simply waste the time he had, waiting for a better life to come back to him.

Nonetheless, he was back here. Last time, he'd made a mistake, he thought and tried to remember. He'd moved somewhere, anywhere he could reach and he felt the same urge rising in his gut. Not this time, he promised himself, gritted his teeth and held still for a moment.

The pitch-black silence around him didn't change when he strained his eyes and ears. Willing to try anything, he closed his eyes and focussed on the sensations envelopping his body. It was beyond unpleasant, the pressure on his ribs from both sides, the hard, unforgiving surfaces that made him almost throw up with sudden claustrophobia.

But then, there was a little something. The unforgiving cold felt a little less harsh on his right side; something like the idea of a warm breeze snaking around his ankle. With a breath as deep as the crushing strain on his body would allow, he started to make his way towards it, forcing his body to move backwards little by little, only by the strength of his arm.

A painstaking eternity later, he could feel a warm sensation, like a faint ray of sunshine, on both his legs. He almost cried with relief and anticipation and dread, but instead kept on budging in that direction, fractions of an inch in what felt like hours.

He almost fell a couple of times, rushes of air so close to him he gasped, but he wasn't quite there yet and so he clenched his jaw and held on to where he was pressed into smooth and unyielding walls.

Finally, he could feel an intense warmth, bordering on heat all on his right side and an opening he reached for with his whole body. One, two, three more pushes away from the

pressure and he fell. This time, he landed on his back and took a moment, inhaling deeply, before opening his eyes.

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The ceiling came into focus as Bucky blinked slowly. It was white with several oddly shaped lights and higher than Bucky had seen except for churches or government buildings. He groaned and sat up, trying to regain his bearings when he noticed someone freeze from the corner of his eye. The vague shape was achingly familiar and Bucky snapped his head around, making his vision spin for a second before he could properly look at the man in the corner of the room.

His hand lay on the doorhandle but he made no effort to move. Instead, his bright blue eyes gaped at Bucky. His blond hair was shorter than Bucky remembered it ever being and he wore a tight undershirt made from a sort of shiny fabric Bucky had never seen before. Hope surged through Bucky as he got to his feet as quickly as the slight nausea would allow for, a teary smile forming on his lips.

God, maybe it had worked after all.

As soon as Bucky started to make his way over to Steve – it had to be Steve, it seemed so right, felt so right – he brought his hand that was previously in position to open the door to his face.

“I got a Loki in the Atrium. Backup needed, now,” he barked into what looked like a watch before he squared up to face Bucky.

“Steve?” Bucky asked, his voice trembling with emotion. Slowly, tentatively, he reached out to his friend because yes, this was *his* Steve, no one else frowned like this, clenched their jaw like this, tensly leaned their body forward like this. Bucky had spent enough time around someone who looked just like him, the same face yet so different in the really small ways that matter the most to *know*. “Steve,” he repeated and his right hand almost touched Steve’s forearm when Steve dodged it as if he expected a punch and resumed his fighting stance one step closer to the left.

“Steve,” Bucky pleaded. “Steve, it’s me.”

Behind him, he heard footsteps, probably the backup Steve called for, but Bucky wasn’t interested in turning around.

“What’s going on, who is this?” a firm, deep voice said from the other end of the room.

“Loki, must be,” Steve hissed, his eyes fierce and narrow. “Or some other shapeshifter, I guess.”

“Last I heard, Thor had a handle on things with Loki. Why are you assuming it’s a shapeshifter?”

“Because he- he looks like- like someone who didn’t make it back from the war.”

There was grief in Steve’s voice underneath all the tension, the temper coloring his tone. It broke Bucky’s heart but he didn’t dare step any closer, not yet. He’d spent enough time getting pummeled by a man with this body and well, it never ended pleasantly, to say the least.

“According to my records and facial recognition program, the unidentified person appears to be an almost perfect match to James Buchanan Barnes who went AWOL in 1943. Captain Rogers and him grew up together and fought in the same combat unit during the Second World War until Barnes’ dissapearance,” another voice rang out from the ceiling, making Bucky flinch and look up.

“What the…” his voice trailed off as Steve eyed him suspiciously.

“Stark tech.” he explained briskly, not lowering his loose fists by an inch.

“Yep, pretty impressive tech at that.” A man with dark hair and an obnoxious beard appeared in Bucky’s peripheral vision and Bucky turned his head slightly towards him as he continued to talk. “What’s got you panties in a twist, Cap? He hasn’t even tried to hit you yet and you look like you’re ready to pounce. I’ve seen you calmer around actual serial killers.”

“Tony,” someone who hadn’t yet talked and had snuck closer to Bucky than he was comfortable with, scolded.

“It’s okay, Nat,” Steve noded in the direction of the new voice, inhaling deeply as he unclenched his jaw.

“What? I, for one, find it very interesting that he gets this upset by someone wearing his friend’s face. I mean, sure, I wouldn’t be thrilled if that happened to me, but I don’t think I’d compromise my heroic ethics for it.”

“He hasn’t compromised anything, Tony, leave it be,” the person with the deep voice behind Bucky tried to appease – unclear whom exactly, but it worked on Steve who finally lowered his arms a little.

“You got anything to say for yourself?” Steve snapped at Bucky.

“Uhm – hi? Hi, Steve, it’s been a while,” Bucky responded with a lopsided smile, doing nothing to hide the fondness in his words. For a split second, Steve’s expression softened before he lightly shook his head and returned to a stoic scowl.

“Let’s get him into questioning,” Steve ordered. “Shackle him and don’t let him out of your sight, we don’t yet know what he’s capable of.”

Hope melted away like snow in the desert sun, leaving Bucky with a gnawing, hollow feeling, unable to say anything.

“Wow, shackle the one-armed man. Really got you riled up, someone imitating Barnes, your *close, personal friend*,” the man Bucky had decided not to like from his facial hair alone teased, raising an eyebrow as he sounded out the words. Both Bucky and Steve turned towards him.

“What exactly is he trying to say?” Bucky asked calmly, dangerously.

“You know what,” Steve muttered under his breath before he caught himself, furrowing hs brows at Bucky once again, this time with more confusion and uncertainty dancing around his eyes.

“Careful, Stark, we once busted a guy’s kneecaps for that kinda thing,” Bucky threw in the direction of the dark-haired man.

“What?” the other three people in the room shouted simultaneously.

“Don’t say it like that,” Steve grimaced and buried his face in his hands, muffling his explanation. “Our landlord’s son sometimes threatened he’d report us, two fellas living together, if he ever saw us do anything queer. We never thought too much of it since, well, he wouldn’t have had anything to see. But then he joked he might tell the police anyways, whether it was true or not. And because neither one of us could afford to go to jail, we, um, made sure he wouldn’t go through with it.”

“He promised not to set a foot in a police station ever again after that,” Bucky grinned darkly. “Had it coming, that little wannabe-tyrant.”

The air was suddenly thick with glances exchanged by the other three and Bucky’s skin began to crawl as Steve froze in place, again. When he let his hand drop, he looked at Bucky as if he was seeing him for the first time.

“Bucky?” he asked, tentatively, trembling a little.

“Hey Steve,” Bucky smiled again, more warmly with new hope growing in his chest.

“Steve, we don’t-“

They both ignored whoever had started to talk and then Bucky hissed with surprise when Steve wrapped his arms around Bucky, pulling him close as he sobbed softly. Sighing with the relief of years of pent-up sorrow slowly fading into the background, Bucky nuzzled into the crook of Steve’s neck and almost choked– because Steve smelled right, unlocking a thousand vague memories of tickle fights, of sleeping next to him, of holding onto each other when it all got a little too much.

After a minute or ten, Steve took a shaky breath and let Bucky go, only to press their foreheads together and smile as bright as the morning sun.

“I know this might feel right, Steve, but-“ the same voice interrupted.

“No one knows that story. Alright? No one. It’s not in any of the history books, the guy is long dead, *there is no way anyone else but Bucky knows that story*,” Steve all but yelled with the stubbornness of a whole pack of mules. “We’ll talk and we’ll figure out together what’s going on here but right now, you have to trust me to make this call.”

The protectiveness in his words made Bucky’s heart swell and he did his best not to swoon. Damn, he’d missed that man.

“Are we gonna talk in this lab, or go somewhere normal?” Bucky went with an almost conversational tone.

“Huh? What do you mean, ‘lab’?” Steve asked, standing up straight and tilting his head with a mix of confusion and worry.

“Uhm- you’re wearing something weird, I assume that’s for protection, the furniture looks all wrong, there’s about a million dohickeys I can’t name in here *and* there’s a Stark, so I assumed it’s a lab,” Bucky slowly exlplained, taking a step back and frowning when a moment of pointed silence followed.

“*A* Stark?” the man himself huffed.

“Yeah, who are you? Howard’s cousin, his brother? I didn’t know there were more of you, to be frank.”

Something akin to panic entered Steve’s expression, further unsettling Bucky. Very calmly, Steve reached out again, smoothing over Bucky’s arm.

“What year is it, Buck?”

“Uh, 1948? Wha- Why?” Bucky answered, more alarmed than he was willing to show.

“Okay.” Another shaky breath from Steve, then he shook his head as if to rid himself of his obvious nervousness before adressing the other people in the room. “All of you, out,” he ordered.

“Steve, you’re not think-“

“That wasn’t a question. Sam, Nat, I know you’re worried, but you need to leave Bucky and me alone *right now*. And please take Tony’s nosy ass with you.”

Bucky heard them hesitate, could feel the tension about to burst into a fight or worse when who he assumed to be Nat turned on her heels and headed for the door, shortly followed by the other two.

“JARVIS, deactivate all surveillanve protocolls for the room.”

“I have to advise against-“ the voice from the ceiling piped up again.

“Jarvis, *now*. And make sure no one gets in here.”

“Yes, sir.”

“Hey Bucky,” Steve said with a smile on his face and tears in his eyes.

“We did this part already,” Bucky winked at him in attempt to lighten the mood. “What’s going on, Steve? You’re acting really weird.”

A broken laugh fell from Steve’s lips before he took another steadying breath.

“That wasn’t Stark’s brother,” Steve answered the question Bucky had already forgotten asking.

“Uhm-“

“That’s his son. Howard was assasinated by some HYDRA goons in the nineties.”

Bucky shook his head.

“The eighteen-nineties? But-“

“No. No, not the eighteen-nineties. The nineteen-nineties.”

Maybe Bucky had been wrong, maybe this wasn’t Steve at all, maybe he was actually dreaming, he thought and it felt wrong, all wrong.

“But- that’s in fifty years from now.”

“Actually, it’s almost twenty-five years ago. Bucky – we’re in the year 2015.”

Bucky’s knees gave in from under him and he slumped onto the ground with Steve quickly crouching next to him.

“Sorry, what?”

“I know, I know, I also didn’t believe it at first-“

“But if it’s twothousand and fifteen-“ Bucky sounded out every syllable of the ridiculous number, to big to be anywhere close to a year he’d ever experience. “-how come you’re not an old man?”

“Oh, I, um, I was kinda frozen in ice for sixtysix years,” Steve admitted as if he had done something wrong. “After you disappeared, we found the Red Skull. In the end, I was on a plane with his bombs and the only way not to blow up half the US, well, had me crashing the thing in the Arctic.”

“Steve!” a yelp broke free from deep within Bucky at the mere thought of it. He quickly abandoned the distance he had kept for the last few minutes and pulled Steve in, cradling him close to his chest. “Goddamnit, Steve, you can’t do stupid shit like that.”

“I know, I know, I really try not to these days, I promise,” Steve mumbled wetly against Bucky’s collarbone, holding him tightly.

“Jesus Christ,” Bucky sighed and carded his fingers through Steve’s hair, stopping just short from loudly inhaling the soft smell of soap and sweat and *Steve* because even under these circumstances, a little decorum was in order.

After a moment, Steve spoke up again.

“They defrosted me, like, four years ago and, well, it’s all been a little crazy from then on.”

“When has it ever not been crazy with you, punk.”

“Jerk.”

They both laughed a little, their bodies shaking against each other.

“Where were you, Buck?”

“I…” His voice trails off, suddenly hoarse with the burst of grief he felt every time he thought about that horrible nightmare that, somehow, became his life. “Remember when I woke up that one time, like a year or so after Azzano, when I said something about going somewhere not by choice, but that it just happened?”

“I do. Wracked my brains over it often enough, wondering whether I should have gotten something from it, whether I could have stopped it somehow.” Steve sounded devastated as he wrapped his arms a little tighter around Bucky’s waist.

“No, no, no. Did you think it was your fault? Did you think I left you?” The silence was damning, sending tears down Bucky’s cheeks. “Oh Steve,” he breathed into his soft hair. “Don’t, please don’t. It just happened, I couldn’t- It was just so hard to breathe and the pressure- I woke up somewhere else. And you weren’t there. Well, there was a guy, Steven, but it wasn’t you.”

Steve furrowed his brows, Bucky could feel it through his thin linnen shirt on his skin.

“’Steven’?”

“Yeah, the place had its own Steven Grant Rogers and he was Captain America alright, but he wasn’t you.” With a helpless shrug, Bucky tried to convey that he really didn’t know how else to explain it.

“That makes no sense.”

“My thoughts exactly. But I didn’t know what to do and they kinda just made me his training partner…“ His voice trailed of at the thought of just how hard it had been to come to gripes with that strange reality he had found himself inside of.

“What about the Commandos?”

“Didn’t have them. Steven was the head of a team of specialists, decent fellows, but nothing like the Commandos. They went on the missions Philips picked for them and in

the meantime, Steven needed to stay fit, so they made me his sparring partner after they saw I could hold my own against him in a fight."

A thieving grin darted across Steve's face.

"You hit the guy?"

"He hit me first, the asshole."

"Sounds insufferable."

"You're insufferable," Bucky replied with ease, muscle memory kicking in as he nudged the still shaken Steve who laughed a little. "But yeah, he was kinda awful, at least at first. We got along okay after a while. But then, my arm got blown off and they shipped me back to New York. I couldn't work at the docks no more, so I got a job with Mrs. Fowler. Remember her?"

A huff escaped Steve's lips, still the same pale-red Bucky remembered.

"I haven't thought of that old crone in forever. God, she always went feral for the bagels by our place."

"Guess how I bribed her into trying me out as her cashier," Bucky smirked. "Brought her three of her favorite bagels all at once"

"How'd you pull that off? She hated your guts after you broke her sweet daughter's heart."

"That's the other thing with that place – I just didn't exist there, or rather, ther was no Bucky Barnes. None of the other Barnes, either. I went to all the adresses I remembered, I tried to find anyone from my family, but somehow, there were no Barnses I knew in all of Brooklyn," he explained while staring into the distance, remembering the time he spent searching for anyone who might know him. Slowly, a realisation crept up on him and his focus snapped back to the present. "Oh my god, my parents, the twins, Becca – are they…?" He couldn't bring himself to finish the question, but then he saw the answer as clear as daylight in Steve's griefstricken face. The horror dawned on him and his arm fell to the side as his body went limp, held up only by Steve. "They're all dead. Everyone – everyone? – we know is dead now, aren't they, Steve?"

"I'm so sorry, Buck."

They sat like that for an hour, then two, then three, before either one of them moved.

"Can I come home with you?"

"Of course," Steve reassured him while gently tugging him upwards until he stood by his side. "And I'll show you around – as soon as you feel up to it."

The drive to Steve's appartment in Washington DC was quiet. Bucky looked out the window at this strange new world he didn't yet trust to be real. But it had to be because Steve was here, solid and reliable and smiling with so much emotion Bucky didn't dare to look at him properly.

At his place, Steve showed him the bathroom and gave him a change of clothes when Bucky said he wanted to shower. The water was pleasantly warm, even after ten minutes of Bucky washing himself with the soft-smelling soap Steve had pointed him towards.

Wearing jeans that fit him a little to snugly and a shirt that was half a size too big for him, Bucky stepped out the bathroom, towelling his hair dry.

"So, what did I miss?" he huffed as he flopped down on the spacious sofa next to Steve.

"Not too much. Couple of wars, several generations of tech that changed how people live their lives, libraries full of books and records and movies. Something like that," Steve shrugged, his nonchalance almost perfectly covering for the fondness in his eyes.

"Ah well, I'm sure I'll catch up in a day or two. Why don't we start with you reading something to me? I'd prefer the movies, of course, but I don't think I'll make it to the cinema without my head spinning from all the new stuff out there."

Excitement crept into Steve's expression and he reached for a little black box with buttons.

"Oh boy, do I have a surprise for you," he said and pressed one of the buttons, looking at the wall opposite the couch. Bucky mirrored him and gaped at the big, black frame mounted there when it suddenly came alive, showing video footage of a forest. "We can watch movies at home now, Buck, they really punched up what a TV can do. So, what do you wanna see? Something old we already know or something new that'll blow your mind?"

"I think my mind's been blown enough for today. Why don't we go with the Wizard of Oz, the one we went to the cinema together to? Can we buy that one?"

"Already have," Steve chuckled, pressing some more buttons and starting the movie.

Bucky must have fallen asleep in front of the TV at some point because when he woke up, he found himself still on the sofa. The panic rising in him was quelled as soon as he spotted Steve who had put a duvet on the floor, his head laying on one of the couch cushion as he snored very faintly. His face looked so soft and young, it made Bucky want to climb on the ground with him and pull him into a tight embrace, whisper in his ear just how much he'd missed him.

The next few days were full of pleasant surprises and sudden bouts of grief, both their emotions running high and in the evenings, they were always wiped, started to watch the Wizard of Oz and fell asleep together on the couch. By the third time it happened, Steve didn't bothered to move to the floor and so Bucky woke up the next morning with a comforting weight pressed against his side. He knew it was Steve even before he opened his eyes, Steve's breathing steady as his chest rose and fell against Bucky's ribs and the remnants of his left shoulder.

"Does it bother you?" Bucky asked an hour later when they had breakfast together and gestured vaguely at the left side of his body. The web of scarring was partly visible under the tanktop he'd taken from Steve's closet.

"Huh?" Steve needed a moment to understand what Bucky was getting at, but when he did, he furrowed his brows with dismay. "No, Bucky, why would you even think that?"

Not quite sure of the answer himself, Bucky just shrugged and proceeded to eat the toast he had lathered in hummus, one of those delicious things that he filed away as a perk of the 21st century. Even if it had existed way before then, it hadn't been part of his breakfast options.

Steve regularly took calls on the small sleek device he called a phone despite how little it looked like one, often rolling his eyes at whoever checked in on him.

"No, we're fine, I promise."
"What did he say?"
"Ugh, I guess so. Tell Fury I'm okay with three months mandatory leave if, and only if, you promise to get me on board when you really need me."

"Hey Bucky!" Steve turned to him one morning. "Sam and Nat wanna come by tomorrow afternoon, whadda you say?"

"Sure! I'd love to meet these new friends of yours, see if they're treating you right," Bucky winked at him and revelled in the small blush on Steve's cheeks.

With a cup of coffee in hand, Bucky overlooked the street in front of the building through the window. It was relatively empty, little dots in muted colors hurrying down the sidewalk every now and then. Everyone was avoiding the pelting rain that sounded almost like it did in New York – but not quite. The cars were strangely shaped, but so were the street lamps that cast a cold glow down on the puddles Bucky could only assume were filling in the potholes.

"Admiring the view?" Steve lightly nudged Bucky as he steped next to him, their shoulders brushing against each other. For a moment, they stayed like this and Bucky did his best not to lean into the man he'd never believed he'd see again.

“D’you know who’s living in our apartment these days?” Bucky asked him back.

With a sigh, Steve scrubbed his hand over his face.

“They knocked down the entire block at some point. I went back there it was all just-gone.”

Bucky hadn’t even considered the possibility, but the certainty that it was gone settled heavily in his stomach. He drank the last bit of coffee and set the mug down on the windowsill.

“That’s a bummer.”

“Sure is,” Steve muttered. “When I saw that nothing was left, I had a moment where I panicked because all the money you had saved under the loose floorboard by the kitchen door was also gone – but then I remembered how little value it’d have today with all those decades of inflation.”

“I was saving for a record player,” Bucky smiled sadly. “Even thought I might be able to pull it off when you were healthy as a horse, all of a sudden.”

“Oh,” Steve just said and furrowed his brow a little bit.

“Yeah, I knew you didn’t like the dancehalls but every time we went, I could see how much you enjoyed the music. So I figured you’d really get something out of being able to listen to a record or two at home.”

It was silent for a solid minute before Bucky heard Steve’s shuddering breath, the telltale sign that he was supressing a sob. Bucky started to fidget with the hem of the soft shirt when Steve slung his right arm around him, pulling into tight hug.

“I’m here, Steve, it’s okay” is all Bucky managed to say before he let himself fall into the embrace.

Sam and Nat were both fantastic company, teasing Steve just as much as Bucky and the four of them quickly fell into a rapid-fire rhythm of conversation.

When they were almost out the door, Nat threw Bucky another glance and he smirked at her.

“Ma’am,” he simply said, earning himself an approving and slightly impressed nod from her and an almost bewildered scoff from Sam.

“Damn, I didn’t know you had game like that! Steve, you should have warned me that I’d be out of a job as the lead charmer of the group,” Sam chuckled.

Bucky joined Steve in the kitchen after hearing a deep sigh and huffed out a small laugh at the sight.

“What are you being dramatic about, now?”

“They brought groceries.”

“I can see that. Does that mean I get to taste more of this new century than the soggy pasta you’ve been making?” Bucky teased him, stepping closer to examine the heap of food on their counter. “Look, they even bought oranges! You used to love those, remember?”

“Yeah,” Steve grumbled with a small smile, moving to wash one of them before cutting it into serveral wedges. “Nat told me to eat them like this when I complained about how annoying it is to peel them. Want one?” he offered.

“No, thanks, maybe later.”

With a shrug, Steve took a piece of orange into his hands and gently bit into it, pulling out the juice and pulp with his teeth while careful not to catch too much of the fruit’s white translucent membranes. Juice ran down his chin and he quickly ducked over the sink next to Bucky.

“Are you sure that’s how Nat did it? I can hardly imagine her ever looking as sloppy as you do right now.”

“Come on, it’s not that bad,” Steve rolled his eyes. “And she sometimes loves to be a little messy, she just rarely lets anyone see.”

“Oh yeah, so she totally had orange juice dripping from here-“ Bucky pointed to Steve’s cheekbones, moving to the other side of his face. “-to here?”

“I know you’re exaggerating, Bucky,” Steve scoffed.

“Am I now?” Bucky asked sarcastically, touching his fingers lightly to Steve’s left cheek where a bit of orange pulp sat and gently dragging it all the way to the edge of Steve’s mouth. Their eyes locked as Bucky brushed against Steve’s slightly parted lips that glisten with the sweet juice of the fruit. For the fraction of a second, Bucky’s heart stopped beating as his finger laid against the sensitive skin and Steve seemed to hold his breath. Then Bucky pulled his hand away, blinking through the rush of longing surging through his body and staring at the cupboards opposite them as Steve bent down to wash his mouth with tapwater.

“It’s all a bit unreal, isn’t it?” Bucky asked that evening as they settled onto the couch, ready for their routine of watching the same movies as the last few days and falling asleep close to each other.

“Sure is. I think if you told me back in Brookly this would happen one day, I’d assume it was the plot of one of the science fiction pulp novels you liked so much.”

“Yeah. Gotta say, though - travelling through time and space by shere coincidence, that’s a bit less heroic than I’d like to imagine myself,” Bucky chuckled. The light of the moon cast sharp shadows on Steve’s face, inscrutible as it seldom was but something soft rippling underneath the surface as he looked at Bucky.

“You have to tell me if you want to sleep in the bed instead. I can take the couch if you wanna, you know, get a proper nights sleep, Buck,” he suddenly said, turning his head to face the dark TV.

“Been sleeping better than I have since 1943,” Bucky muttered almost under his breath, not quite sure whether Steve would mind.

“So have I,” he simply responded and turned the TV on.

“What are you spending your time with when you’re not explaining the future to a man from the las century?” Bucky asked after breakfast while trying his best to navigate the phone Steve had ordered for him.

“Uhm, work?”

“Ugh, there’s gotta be something you do for fun. Been dancing a lot?”

“One, that was always your idea of fun, not mine and two, I don’t think people still dance like that, in pairs with, like, specific steps. It’s all different now – or so I’ve been told. I haven’t checked for myself, I gotta admit.” His voice sounded a little hoarse as he said that, causing Bucky to look up and chuck the phone into his lap to reach out to touch Steve’s arm.

There was something like regret ghosting over his face, and a hint of guilt as well like he’d been neglecting himself. He must have, Bucky thought and considered the things he’d been telling him about the time since he was out of the ice. It seemed as if Steve had not lived the last few years, not really, Bucky realized but quickly decided against scolding him for it – he’d be a hypocrite if he did.

“You still draw though, right?” Bucky tried to reach for a safer bet and immediately regretted it when a sorrowfull expression dawned on Steve’s face.

“They took my sketchbooks. I- I know I can buy new ones but it feels so wrong not to have my old drawings,” he said quietly.

“Who’s ‘they’?”

“The Smithsonian has them. Guess the military made sure they got all my stuff for their exhibit on Captain America.” A mocking tone entered Steve’s voice as he sounded out every syllable of his own alias.

“But you’re still alive. They haven’t given them back yet?”

“No,” Steve simply replied as a realisation crept up on Bucky and he blurted out: “So people just look at them? In the museum? They have your sketch of me on display there, too?”

“No, they’re in storage and- wait a second.” Panic flited across Steve’s face as his breathing sped up. “I never showed you- how do you know I drew you?”

“Oh, uhm.” Bucky felt his cheeks light up like brushfire, fumbling for words that would make it sound less like a betrayl of their trust. “Steve, I- I often looked at your drawings when you were out and I was bored or when you were in the hospital. But I swear to god it was an accident that I opened the sketchbook the wrong way around.”

Steve looked down at his hands, his shoulders suddenly hunched by some terrible weight Bucky never meant to place there.

“Please listen, Steve. When I saw the page, realized you’d drawn me – it felt like maybe you didn’t want me to know, so I never told you. I’m really sorry, Steve, I never meant to break your trust.”

Silence filled the space between like thick fog, the air viscid with tension until Bucky couldn’t bear it no more, barelling on with his explanation even though he feared it might make things worse.

“I thought about it a lot when- when I lost you or when I got lost or whatever we’re calling it – because the first thing I started to forget was who I was. It gnawed at me, the feeling that it was slipping away from me, the life I’d had, the person I’d been. And so I thought about how you’d drawn me, slouching in our rickety kitchen chair in my work clothes, hair messy and so goddamn exhausted but grinning like I didn’t have a worry in the world.”

Steve buried his head in his hands, breath steady in a way that could only mean he was forcing it to be that way.

“Steve, I’m really sorry,” Bucky repeated, desperation seeping from his words.

“So you knew?” Steve asked to Bucky’s confusion.

“Knew what? Yeah, I knew that you sketched me,” he answered honestly and a little surprised at the question.

After a minute of Steve’s eyes roaming over his face, searching for something, he sighed and nodded. “Okay. Okay, okay.” A deep breath swooshed from Steve’s lips. “I’m not mad, Buck, just- I was just scared it might bother you.”

“It didn’t, why should it? I’m honored you thought me worthy of being drawn, Steve.”

Another look at Bucky, indecipherable and wary, and Steve stood up.

“I’m making some tea, you want some as well?”

The soft sounds of a saxophone, piano and some percussion swayed from the speakers in the living room. According to Sam, this track was the perfect introduction to everything both Bucky and Steve had missed in the decades they weren’t around.

Bucky was stirring finely chopped zucchini and brokkoli in a pan, closely following the instructions he had found in an online recipe book while Steve washed some rice, humming along to the now familiar soundtrack.

“Remember the O’Brians two streets over?” Bucky remenisced as the next song started to play.

“Yeah, you and Dottie O’Brian had a thing going for a while,” Steve replied and gently swished water through the sieve.

“Their oldest, Tommy, he had come back from the front lines a few months before me, missing the other arm. We used to joke that together, we could tie a windsor knot as well as anyone,” Bucky grinned as Steve huffed a small laugh.

“You hang out a lot?”

“For a while. Real great fella, used to ask his handyman cousin for a discount whenever my fridge broke down.” Bucky turned down the heat of the stove and reached for the soysauce, measuring two tablespoon and splashing them over the vegetables.

“Sounds like good friend. Must’ve been tough for him, loosing his right hand and all that.” Steve weighed his head in sympathy as he transferred the rice into a pot and added water.

“He learnt really quickly, though. Within half a year, he could write better than before or so he said. Apparently, he’d favored his left in school, but the nuns beat it outta him.”

With a disapproving sound undoubtedly directed at the unfair treatment by his teachers, Steve put the rice on the stove and set a timer.

“Smells nice what you’re making there, Buck,” he smiled as he leaned against the counter close next to Bucky who smiled right back.

“I can’t believe you still haven’t figured out how to make a decent meal from scrap, lazybones,” Bucky scolded amusedly.

“Guess I was counting on you coming back,” Steve responded with his eyes fixed to the ground, his long lashes fanned out, almost touching his soft skin. An ache surged through Bucky as he took a moment to look at him.

“I think I’ll be going for a run tomorrow, wanna join? Sam’ll be there as well,” Steve suggested after dinner.

“Sure, I’ll tag along.”

They both had their legs stretched out under the table, knocking their ankles together every now and then, moving slowly with the tired contentment that comes with a well-cooked meal.

“Do you think you could give me Sam’s and Nat’s phone number so I can text them, too? If you’re comfortable with that, of course, don’t wanna steal your friends or anything,” Bucky cautiosly asked, unsure of whether or not Steve would mind. Before, they’d mostly shared a friend circle except for Bucky’s dancing partners and Steve’s fellow artists, although they’d never called themselves that.

“I can give you Sam’s. He likes you, too,” Steve smiled earnestly. “Nat’s a little difficult to reach, she doesn’t really stick with one phone but I could give her your number and she might call you sometime. If it ever says ‘unknown caller’, it’s either a scam or Nat. Took me a while to figure that out because the people at SHIELD had warned me of unidentified callers.”

“You never were all that tech savy, were you,” Bucky teased with a wink before he glanced down. “How’d you meet the two, anyways?”

“Nat’s been working with SHIELD for a while and we kinda had to take it apart last year when it came to light that HYDRA had infiltrated it. And Sam-”

“HYDRA as in kidnapped me and experimented on me HYDRA?” A cold shiver trickled down Bucky’s spine. He hadn’t thought of them in a long time, the cold facility, the merciless prodding by detatched scientists-

“Yeah, they managed to regroup after the war despite all of Peggy’s efforts. She found the records showing what they were planning to do with-“ Steve clenched his jaws and his eyes darted to Bucky.

“With?” he asked, unsure of whether he wanted to hear it.

“With you, Buck. I was so scared they might have gotten to you after all when I read the dossiers compiled by Peggy, but they apparently scrapped their plans for that after the Red Skull died.”

Bucky took a deep breath, counting to five before exhaling.

“I’m never letting anyone lay a hand on you,” Steve promised, clasping his hand on Bucky’s forearm. The warmth of his fingers seeped through the sleeve of Bucky’s shirt, grounding him. “I’m with you ‘til the end of the line.”

It was very early when they left the appartment and Bucky was thankful for avoiding the hustle and bustle of the morning rush hour. He was already close to needing a nap from all the new and unfamiliar things surrounding him when they reached the park.

Sam hugged both of them tightly in greeting before they started to jog on the loose gravel. Steve had lent Bucky a pair of new running shoes; they felt light and comfortable on Bucky's feet.

The first round, they kept to a slower pace, all three of them running together before Steve nudged Bucky at the start of the second round.

"Ready to do some running, pal?"

"Always," Bucky grinned at him as Sam sighed behind them.

"Great, now there's two of you. I really should have thought about that beforehand," he grumbled as the other two sped up.

For the next three rounds, Bucky and Steve limited themselves to running at a pace they could still hold a conversation without slowing down.

"This is all you got, Rogers?" Bucky teased as he started to dart forward, threatening to leave Steve behind.

"Oh no, my friend, you'll see," Steve responded and caught up quickly. "Now it's on."

After another two rounds of frantically racing each other, they decided to join Sam again. There were more people more around them now, some of them holding paper cups, some of them chatting idly in little groups, some of them wearing what looked like electronic ear muffs. As far away as New York was, the background noise of a city calmed Bucky down and he took a deep breath when he spotted two men rounding a corner, laughing as one slipped his hand into the other's.

"I think I saw some cops on the other side of the park," Bucky remarked and turned to Steve and Sam who seemed surprised at the comment. His attempt to explain himself with a nod in the direction of the two men he had spotted earned him nothing but confused frowns.

"We should warn them? Of the cops?"

When that did nothing but deepen both their frown lines, Bucky moved a little closer, careful not to raise his voice and possibly attract unwanted attention.

"The two men, they're holding hands. Gotta be some pretty brave fellas but maybe they don't want to spend their day together in a cell?"

Realisation dawned on Steve's face and he huffed with relief.

“Bucky, it’s no longer illegal for men to go with other men – or women with women, for that matter.”

It took a moment for the words to sink in as impossible as they sounded.

“Oh!” Bucky finally said, a little too loud to his own ears. “Oh, that’s good. How’d that happen?”

“That didn’t just happen, buddy, people fought really hard for it,” Sam replied seriously. “Illegal demonstrations and riots and so much more while people like Ronald fucking Reagan did their best to make their lives miserable.”

“But that’s not the handsome devil from the movies Ronald Reagan, is it?” Bucky asked a little incredioulously.

“Emphasis on devil, Buck. He became president in ’81 and had a hand in just about every problem in the US today,” Steve scoffed with contempt.

“People voted for an actor as president?!”

“If only his acting career was his biggest crime,” Sam muttered.

Bucky heard the blood rushing through his ears when Steve unlocked the door to his appartment. This was his chance, he knew, because if he didn’t do it right now, he would have never done it.

“Steve?”

He turned to Bucky, worry crinkling his forehead at the serious tone.

“Yeah?”

“The two men in the park…” Avoiding Steve’s eyes, Bucky sat down on the edge of the dinner table and crossed his arms in front of his chest. He let his gaze roam over Steve’s broad frame, his tilted head, his high cheekbones for just a second before looking down to the floor. “I’m like them.”

There was silence before Steve made a sort of strangled and confused noise.

“I- I sucked off some guys. In the army and before that, down at the docks.” Bucky lifted his head to see a brightly blushing Steve frozen in place. Their eyes locked. The intensity of Steve’s stare started to make Bucky’s palms sweat.

“Does that make you uncomfortable?” Bucky whispered. This seemed to snap Steve out of it as he frantically shook his head.

“No! No, no, no, I just didn’t expect- I’m totally fine with- I mean, I’m so happy that it’s less dangerous now and I’m glad you get to enjoy that as well.” Steve smiled a little unsurely

and fidgeted with the label on the bottle he'd grabbed from the fridge. "Oh, you want some water as well?"

Bucky nodded and easily caught the bottle Steve threw him.

"It wasn't fake with the women, though. Is that- Is that something that's a problem?" Bucky continued. If he was doing this, he wanted to do it right.

"People who date men and women are called bisexual, I think," Steve answered quickly.

"Bisexual, huh," Bucky tried the word. The syllables felt unfamiliar on his tongue but he was glad to have a term that sounded nothing like what bullies called Steve when they beat him up. If only they'd known, Bucky thought, which one of them really was the queer one. But then again, it wouldn't have mattered to these crude types because all they really meant by it was someone they saw as weaker as them, someone they had every right to push around.

"Did you ever- with the other- the other Captain America?" Steve asked hastily, his voice a little hoarse as he averted his eyes.

"God, no," Bucky replied staunchly and a little dumbfounded. "I was glad when we were past the point of nearly beating each other up for real every time we sparred. No way in hell I'd have-" An unpleasant shiver jolted through Bucky at the mere thought.

"He sounds godawful."

"He wasn't, though. Honestly, he was a decent fella, did real good work in the war and even came by to visit me once after. Not too much fun to talk with and damn, that man could hold a grudge, but he stood up for what's right when it mattered," Bucky explained in an effort to defend Steven. It wasn't his fault he wasn't Steve, after all.

"Wonder what that says about me, about who I would have become if not for you, Buck," Steve said, self-loathing oozing from his words like muddy swamp water.

"Steve, don't- I can tell you nothing good waits down that path. Wanna know how much time I spent wondering who I might have turned out to be without you? A bully, that's what I came back to again and again, because you were the one who never let me get away with my bullshit, you made me care about more than what people thought of me and without that, I don't trust I would have ever even considered standing up for anything other than myself."

Steve shook his head adamantly.

"No, Buck, that's not- You care so deeply, you did so much for me-"

"Yeah, and you're so trusting and kind, I can't ever imagine *you* being any different. So please don't start torturing yourself over who you might have turned out to be because we just don't know, there might be hundreds of thousands of other worlds out there. All I know

is that you're you and you're the best person I know. You can't take who Steven was to mean anything about who you are."

For a moment, Steve jutted his jaw defiantly, narrowing his eyes as if to prepare for a fight – but the words Bucky expected never came. Steve just looked at him, his hardened features softening with every second until he sighed, sounding devasted.

"I don't know what's worse – missing your face as much as I did every single day you were gone or you having to see someone wear mine," Steve muttered heavily.

"Don't think it matters. We're back here now, aren't we?" Bucky smiled with a mix of sadness and hope sloshing through his veins. The gentle sorrow on Steve's face made him want to reach out, pull him in, bury his nose in his hair, but Bucky still felt too sweaty and gross from the run for that. Plus he wasn't all that sure whether Steve might feel differently about it now that Bucky told him about – well. He hadn't told him everything and he intended to keep it that way. Still, there was a familiar ache of guilt gnawing at him incessently, it's little teeth scraping on the edges of Bucky's very being with every breath.

Sam and Nat came by the next day, both looking a little disheveled with a little cut on Nat's cheek and a shiner starting to bloom on the right side of Sam's face.

"Minor inconvenienve," Nat dismissed Steve's worried expression as she entered the living room. "Classified inconvenience as well, so don't even try the routine with the puppy dog eyes."

"So glad to hear those work on other people as well, I started to think there was something wrong with me," Bucky grinned. "If the infamous Black Widow also has a hard time saying no to them, it has to be a superpower. Erskine would be proud of this side effect, I'm sure."

"I'm pretty sure they worked on you just fine before the serum, Bucky," Steve shot back, amusement deepening the faint wrinkles around his eyes as he cut the cake Bucky had made for the four of them. They settled onto the couch, each with a plate and fork in hand.

"I guess asking you about your jobs is kinda obsolete," Bucky broke the content silence of four people enjoying some nice crumble cake with plums. "Not quite sure how the whole getting to know people works this century, especially when the most straightforward opening is off the table." He kept his tone casual and friendly even though his heart thrummed with nervousness. A few years ago – or a lot of years ago, depending on how to look at it – he was so good as socializing, easily charming almost anyone into a conversation, balancing quips with the odd compliment. But the loneliness had made it all more difficult, he felt rougher around the edges, exposed in the midst of three friends who shared so much in this world Bucky still had so much to learn about.

"Honestly, we're pretty boring people all in all," Sam admitted and shrugged.

“Speak for yourself. I, for one, am very interesting,” Nat scoffed and rolled her eyes with fondness before adding: “But yeah, I mostly hang out with my neighbor’s cat on the roof or watch copious amounts of reality TV when I’m not on missions or training. And spend my time traing to set Steve up on dates, of course.”

A pang of jealousy rushed through Bucky and he quickly shoveled a forkfull of cake into his mouth to hide the sour expression he felt like making.

“You do that on missions as well,” Steve huffed.

“What about you, Sam? I don’t see a ring on your finger – no one make an honest man out of someone as handsome as you?” Bucky tried to get back to his relaxed demeanor, winking at him for good measure.

“Not yet – why? Are you offering?” he grinned handsomely at Bucky and cocked an eyebrow.

“Keep looking at me like that and I might just.”

Nat chuckled as the two men held eye contact in what felt like a flirtatious challenge.

“Damn, Steve, I wouldn’t have complained about his charm if I had known he’d be this generous with it. I offically retract my statement from last week,” Sam finally turned to Steve who grumbled: “Yeah, generous *with you*.”

“Don’t be mad, Steve, I read on the Internet that it’s a bad idea to flirt with straight men,” Bucky tried to appease him and nudged him lightly.

“But Sam…” Steve started a sentence and let it trail off, looking at Sam who shrugged and made a vaguely disagreeing sound.

“Doesn’t seem like you need help with getting to know us at all,” Nat said in Bucky’s direction. “Got us figured out more than Steve has.”

“I wouldn’t put it like that. I’m sure there’s lots more to discover about you,” Bucky replied with a mix of gentleness and heat he remembered like muscle memory from countless evenings in the dancehalls, his eyes fixed on Nat’s.

“See, and now I’m jealous again.” Sam threw his hands in the air in an obviously exagerated gesture.

“I’m not, by the way,” Steve abruptly said as they put plates in the dish washing machine without looking up.

“Hm?” Bucky had been caught up in trying to assess whether the other two liked him and whether he did something weird or inappropriate. It was nothing new; for as much as he seemed at ease around people, he’d always spent hours thinking about every single interaction.

“What you were implying. When you were, uhm, flirting with Sam.” Steve’s voice sounded hard but almost hollow, like he’d spent the last twenty minutes working up the courage to open his mouth.

“Sorry, I’m not quite sure- what are you not?” Bucky asked, now fully focussed on his friend who seemed to struggle with himself for a few beats.

“I’m not straight,” Steve finally pressed out and inhaled deeply as if the words had blocked his airways.

“Oh. That’s- I’m happy for you,” Bucky replied and hoped the shakiness he felt zing through his body didn’t show.

“Do you feel weird about it?”

“Well, that’d be rich, coming from me,” Bucky huffed with amusement.

“Still could be-“

“Steve, I don’t feel weird about it. Don’t worry your pretty little head about it, okay?” Bucky tried for a earnest and light tone, gripping Steve’s wrist to get him to finally look up. When their eyes met, Bucky smiled as brightly as he could.

“’m not little anymore, Buck,” Steve grumbled after a second and went back to putting used cups on the upper rack in the dishwasher.

Bucky’s phone rang when he was blowdrying his hair. It wasn’t strictly necessary but he enjoyed the warmth and he’d finally figured out how to get his short hair to do something other that stick up in odd angles. The noise yanked him out of absentmindedly carding his fingers through his damp hair. ‘Unknown Caller’ the screen said.

“Hello?” Bucky cautiously answered.

“Nat here, obviously. I need you to tell me whether there’s any foods Steve’s allergic to or doesn’t like.”

“Uh- uhmm,” he stuttered, surprised at the question. “He used to get hives from all sorts of foods but that’s changed with the serum. Generally, he’ll eat anything you put in front of him – gotta, wouldn’t survive with those non-existant cooking skills of his – but he preferes crisply fried stuff over anything boiled.”

“Good to know.”

“Why are you asking?”

“You’ll find out soon enough,” Nat sounded like she was grinning.

“Oh, wait for a second, I have something I’d like to ask you, if it’s not too much trouble?”

“I’m all about trouble, actually.”

“Nat says we have to be at this adress tonight at 8pm, sharp.” Steve furrowed his brows while showing an adress to Bucky.

“We as in both of us?”

“Yeah. We could stop by Peggy’s on the way there?” Steve suggested and Bucky nodded with a heavy feeling settling into his stomach. He’d been glad to hear that she was still around, the only person he knew from back then apart from Steve, but then Steve told him about her condition. They couldn’t even be sure whether she’d recognize Bucky and that hurt, to have lost so many people already and to face to possibility of being a stranger to someone he respected so deeply.

“Can you cut my hair before, though? Just like you did in the army?” Maybe it would help if he looked more like he did when they’d spent evenings strategizing together.

“Sure thing, Buck.”

With his hair almost exactly like it was during Bucky’s time with the Commandos, he stepped into the room where Peggy sat in a bed. She was so old, her skin weathered and her movements slow, but her eyes sparkled just as Bucky remembered them.

“Sergeant. I was wondering when you’d finally swing by,” she smiled, a little softer than Bucky ever saw her do, at least when talking to him. It almost consoled him over her apparently forgetting that he’d been missing for the last seven decades.

“Agent Carter. I would have brought you flowers but you were always so unimpressed with my charming ways.”

They laughed, all three of them and Bucky felt Steve’s hand on the small of his back, gently pushing him into the room. He’d been glued to the spot just past the door without even noticing.

“Well, I think this one will appreciate them a little more than I could these days,” Peggy replied with a nod in Steve’s direction and Bucky chuckled as he feels his cheeks getting hotter.

“Not with you around, he only ever has eyes for you,” Bucky refuted, ignoring how it hurt to admit.

“Don’t be too sure of that. I did catch him kissing that blonde who took care of the paperwork, didn’t I?” she teased and Steve groaned, burying his face in his hands.

“You’ll never let that go, will you?”

“Trust me, I won’t,” she said with a wink. “So, what are you two boys up to? I hear Phillips has planned for you to capture another base as soon as the snow lets up, but I’m not sure our intel is correct. Maybe we should wait for the other Howlies, Monty and Gabe are out to scope out the area, aren’t they?”

Bucky and Steve exhanged a glance, a wave of mourning washing over Bucky’s suddenly shivering body.

“Yeah, Peggy, let’s talk about that tomorrow. It’s already a little late today, isn’t it?” Steve soothed her as confusion settled onto her expression.

“No but it can’t be, it’s raining outside, not snowing,” she muttered more to herself than her guests. “And these sheets, they’re all wrong – why are you standing in my bedroom? That’s no way to treat a lady now, is it?”

Steve’s adam apple bobbed visibly as he swallowed and so Bucky responded instead:

“It’s my fault, Peggy, you know how bad my manners can be at times. But we wanted to say goodbye now in case we have to get up too early tomorrow. Wouldn’t wanna wake you just because Philips thinks it best to make us march out in the least godly hours of the day.”

There was a tremble in Peggy’s lower lip and she lightly shook her head before closing her eyes and taking a deep breath.

“You’re darn right I’m not sacrificing my sleep for you silly boys,” she asserted with a hard edge to her smile. A tear rolled down her left cheek but she didn’t seem to notice. “Best of luck and- look out for each other.”

A little hunched over, Steve took her hand and placed a quiet kiss on the back of it.

“Always do, Peggy. And you take a rest now, will you?”

“I think I will.” Her eyes went unfocussed for a moment before she smiled at Bucky. “I’m glad you’re back, James.”

Neither one of them said anything as they walked out of the facility, the smell of flowers and disinfectant following them past the reception. Bucky felt gratefull, so grateful for having had the chance to talk to her for at least a little bit while she recognized him. He’d missed her more than he’d been able to admit to himself; there had also been no Peggy Carter where he had ended up with Steven and a New York without the Barnses. But hearing her voice, now hoarse with age and shaky with her illness, it was something he hadn’t known to dread. Peggy’s always been the sharpest one of them, the quickest wit in any room she was in and to see her struggling to get things right was devastating.

But she was still here. And people obviously cared for her, her bedside table crammed with little notes and trinkets, the vase in her room full of a delicate, fresh bouquet and her hair carefully arranged into soft curls.

Steve opened the car with the remote key that made beeping noises and got in, blankly staring ahead as Bucky settled onto the firm fabric of the car seat.

“Thanks for taking me,” he said quietly and reached out to put his hand on Steve’s thigh. It was a little awkward, he had to fully twist to face Steve to touch him but he wanted him to feel that he wasn’t alone.

“Thanks for coming with me.” Steve’s voice sounded flat but he covered Bucky’s hand with his own, gently squeezing it.

“Of course. We can go together next time, as well.”

“I’d like that,” Steve almost whispered and took a deep breath. “Okay. Ready for whereever Nat is sending us?”

“Let’s go.”

The location was a little off the beaten track. They’d passed the suburbs a while back and drove through what seemed like an old forrest when the voice inside the car told them to stop on a small bed of gravel on the right side of the road. With a glance to Bucky and a small shrug, Steve complied and they both got out of the car.

“Probably this way?” Bucky suggested, pointing down a well-trodden path winding through the tall trees.

“I guess so.”

And they weren’t wrong as they discovered just minutes later. The path lead them to what looked like a cottage, spacious but not ostentatios, completely sheltered from the noise that might come from the street.

“I don’t think we’ve ever been this punctual,” Bucky winked when he checked the time. 8 pm, sharp.

The heavy wooden door swung open and a tall woman emerged, her hair fixed tightly into a bun and her smile calm and inviting.

“I’m very happy to welcome you here. My name is Tanya and I’ll be your host for the evening.”

“Thank you,” Bucky replied while Steve seemed to lag behind. “To what do we owe the honor?”

“Natasha has planned a little something for the two of you. She and Sam unfortuanetly can’t make it, but she assumed this would suffice,” Tanya explained while ushering the two men inside and guiding them to a comfortable nook in the warmly decorated restaurant. A table for two was already set there, one place setting with all the cuttlery on the right side of the plate.

“I think I figured out where I’m sitting,” Bucky grinned at Steve who still looked a little overwhelmed, so Bucky gently squeezed his shoulder. “Don’t worry, I’m pretty sure Nat didn’t bring us here to be executed,” he added and delighted in Steve’s small chuckle.

“This is out menu for the evening,” Tanya said while she handed them both an elegant sheet, the paper thick and coarse in a refined way that fit right in with the dark wood around them, elegantly matched with cream walls and light green highlights.

‘Regular People Food’ it was written in bold letters on top of the menu.

“Is that the name of this restaurant?” Bucky asked a little incredulously. If it was, someone *really* wasn’t in touch with anyone close to regular people. Back in New York, neither Steve nor him would have ever even considered breathing the air in a place like this; the shere expensiveness of the place a stronger deterrent than any bouncer ever could be.

“No, it’s one of Nat’s elaborate *things*. You see, we had do skip my birthday dinner because of a mission and when she asked me what I would have wanted, I said ‘just some regular people food’. Never thought she’d take it to this level but then again, I could have known. I think she pretends to prank people to hide how well she likes to treat her friends.” Fondness glowed through the sheepish look on Steve’s face and Bucky barely resisted the urge to drop the menu and grab his hand instead.

“On a regular night, we’re called Chez Pomeline, but don’t let Natasha hear that I told you,” Tanya smiled. “I’ll give you a minute to select your drinks and see for yourself whether the main is to your liking. From what I’ve heard, you just wanted a meal and some nice desert after and I think, we can give you that,” she added in Steve’s direction before disappearing behind a Staff Only door.

“I really like friends, I gotta say,” Bucky smiled.

And boy, did he ever as he made his way through a huge plate of assorted simple yet excellent dishes; the perfect mix of fried goodness, gravy-soaked little heavens and tasty vegetable bits straight out of a dream. The wine Tanya had recommended was smooth and sweet with just enough tang to bring out the flavors of every single one of the dishes they’d placed in the indentations and on the elevations of the fine, handmade plate.

Bucky was happier than he remembered ever being before. The only thing that could rival the food was the carefree expression that slowly spread on Steve’s face as he laughed and grinned, as they talked about nothing and everything just like they’d always done. Not that

he had questioned it, but it was so comforting to *feel* that nothing had changed, nothing that mattered, anyways.

“This was- just- so good- I can’t even,” Steve stuttered after Tanya had removed their desert plates.

“What he said,” Bucky shrugged helplessly, overcome with the pleasant warm feeling of being taken care off, and turned back to Steve who had raised his eyebrows as Tanya left.

“Who are you and what did you do with the formidable Bucky Barnes. How come you didn’t launch your whole charm offensive at her?”

“Uhm,” Bucky made a noncommittal noise.

“Come on, don’t tell me the 21st century robbed you of your silver tongue.”

“Oh, what do you know about my tongue, anyways. And if you must know – I was holding back to not steal the attention away from you since this is your belated birthday dinner and all that,” Bucky lied as best he could, a mischievous grin emphasising the wink he threw in Steve’s direction. He didn’t have to know Bucky hadn’t even considered flirting with anyone except maybe him, especially not when the warm light made his lips look so soft and red.

“What a gentlemanly move in your old days,” Steve teased.

“Old days?!”

“I mean, you were born all the way back in 1917. That’s ancient nowadays!”

Before Bucky had a chance to retort anything, Tanya came back with her hands behind her back.

“And now for the cherry on top. The kitchen had several options for the digestif but they all seemed rather inadequate compared to what your friend here had already ordered in advance.” She smiled at Steve who glanced at Bucky.

“First I’m hearing of this, pal,” Bucky responded to the silent question in Steve’s eyes.

With a careful movement, Tanya handed Steve something rectangular and flat wrapped in simple brown paper.

“Natasha wants you to know no one was allowed to have a look. She made sure of it.”

“How many people did she threaten?” Steve grumbled as he slowly folded the paper open.

“Just enough to be sure,” Tanya responded, but Steve didn’t even register, judging by how enraptured he seemed by what he held in his hands.

The blue fabric covering the sketchbook had darkened a bit at the edges, worn with time and the pages had yellowed ever so slightly when Steve opened it on the table, his fingers

shaking. Streets, the Brooklyn Bridge, a few trees, a handfull of pigeons fighting over a bit of bagel – the pages were filled with so many little pieces of the home Bucky and Steve had both lost. Bucky felt himself get teary eyed when Steve lifted his head again.

“I just asked Nat whether she might be able to do something – I guessed if anyone could, it’d be her,” Bucky smiled a little helplessly at the shere breadth of emotion washing over Steve’s face.

“Some other personal items the museum felt beholden to return will be delivered to your doorstep within the next week,” Tanya added. “As for tonight – feel free to stay as long as you want and order anything you want from our bar.”

Then it was just the two of them again, the muffled chatter of the other customers comfortably shrouding them as their eyes locked again. Steve’s wistful expression made Bucky reach out and awkwardly pat him on the upper arm when all the wanted to do was pull him into a tight hug and press soft kisses into his hair. He looked so old and so young at the same time, a man who had seen too much and lived too little, fought again and again and again and lost so much.

“God, Buck…” His voice trailed off.

“I know, Steve, I know.”

They sat there for a long time in silence and everything in Bucky screamed to get closer – but then again, it always did, he’d just gotten used to overhearing it.

The drive back home felt a little lighter, they listened to the Trouble Man soundtrack again and talked about the amazing evening Nat had planned out for them. Back at the apartment, Bucky turned on the warmer floorlights as Steve settled onto the couch and browsing through this sketchbook.

“How’d you know it was really me?” Steve asked suddenly when Bucky sat down to his left. His eyes were fixed on the drawing of a younger Bucky slouching on a chair with an easy grin on his face, a days work behind him and a night of dancing waiting for him.

Feeling so much older than the version of himself currently sitting in Steve’s lap on thin, yellowed paper, Bucky could do little more than shrug.

“Felt right, you know?”

Steve breathed in heavily and closed the sketchbook, setting it on the table and staring at the wall opposite him instead.

“I’m just so scared it might happen again. Every time I wake up, I think you might be gone,” he whispered, sounding lost and hollow.

“I don’t- I found my way back, didn’t I? I’ll always find my way back to you, you have to believe me,” Bucky tried to reassure him but his voice broke.

“What if you don’t even notice it next time? You might end up somewhere with someone who looks just like me, but for real this time, and I’ll be stuck here without you and you won’t even know to look for me.”

It tore Bucky to pieces to hear Steve so sorrowful, inconsolable and in pain.

“No, no, no- Steve.”

Determination flooded through Bucky as he turned to face Steve, gently cradling his left cheek in his hand and looking him in the eyes. He’d planned to never do this, but if it was for Steve’s sake, it was easy. Everything to let him know just how much he mattered to Bucky, even if he’d never feel it in the same way for him.

“You wanna know how I was so sure it was you? Ever since I met you, I’ve spent hours and hours looking at you. And when I wasn’t looking at you, I was thinking about you – the way your furrow your brows when you disagree but not enough to interrupt whoever’s talking, the way your eyes sparkle when you laugh, the way you tilt your head when you’re seriously considering something.”

The words spilled out of Bucky like a tidal wave he’d barely contained for all those years.

“I’ve got it all memorized, how you hold your fists when you expect a fight, how you smile shyly when someone says something sweet to you and means it, how you roll your eyes when you want to seem annoyed but can barely hold back a chuckle. It was so weird, I could still hear that quiet, deep voice of yours when you told me you wouldn’t let me go, the hurt noise you made when I showed you my conscription notice, the soft snore when you had fallen asleep on the couch before I came home, I could still hear all of that so clearly, even when I thought I’d never get to see you again. It was the only piece of home I had with me there and you better believe me that I’d recognise it anywhere. So don’t ever doubt that I’ll know whether it’s you because I could find you in a whole sea of men who look just like you.”

Steve stared at him, his eyes wide with surprise and something else Bucky couldn’t quite make out but hoped wasn’t anger.

“All the way back then?” Steve finally asked incredulously, sounding a little strangled.

“Yeah,” Bucky admitted with a smile because at least he could be honest about it now.

“And you knew, you *knew* all the way back then…?”

“I was fooling myself for a good while, assuming everyone felt that way about their best friend. But then Dottie asked me when I was gonna propose because we’d been going out for eight months and all I could think about was leaving you, having to move out of our apartment and how little I wanted to do that. Kinda figured what was going on after that.”

With an apologetic expression, Bucky shrugged and brushed his fingers over Steve's cheek one last time before pulling back his hand – only to freeze when Steve grabbed his wrist, his grip firm but gentle.

"No, Bucky, I meant- you knew about me back then?"

"About you?" Bucky repeated confused.

"Yeah, about me. What, you really think the guy who drew you about a hundred times, shirtless at that, didn't have some more than friendly feelings towards you?"

When Bucky didn't respond but gaped at Steve, he huffed a laugh.

"And people call me oblivious. Bucky, I've been sweet on you since forever. I think I would have enjoyed dancing just fine if it hadn't come at the cost of watching you flirt with someone else so fragrantly it would have made a sailor blush. Every time you took your shirt off I was sure I was gonna die from the heart palpatations it gave me. How- how did you not know that?"

"You're one to talk," Bucky retorted more out of habit than anything else and they stared at each other for another moment before they broke out into laughter, relief sloshing through Bucky.

When they calmed down again, Steve glanced at his hand still holding Bucky's arm.

"Can I…?" Bucky asked cautiously and raised his eyebrow as he slowly started to move closer to Steve.

"God, please," he replied and tugged him onto his lap. "I really thought we'd never do this."

Steve's breath was hot on Bucky's throat and he looked up at him, his eyes so open and earnest Bucky could barely stand it. Swallowing hard, Bucky traced the lines of Steve's face – his high cheekbones, his expressive eyebrows, his curved lips, the faint wrinkles on his forehead, the ones next to his eyes and the ones framing his mouth. It all seemed surreal to Bucky and yet, he felt Steve's chest rise and fall against his own body as he tilted his head down and searched for any sign to back off. But Steve smiled, small and quietly as he closed his eyes and closed the distance.

His lips were soft and warm and better than anything Bucky had ever imagined. He couldn't help himself but breathe a happy little sigh as they kissed, carefully and slowly. Steve's hands settled onto his waist, his thumbs gently caressing the sensitive skin through the fabric of Bucky's shirt. The tenderness of the touch felt almost reverent and made the want rush through Bucky's body, his nerves now zinging with anticipation as he deepened the kiss. He let his hand tangle in Steve's soft hair when Steve's lips parted and Bucky could feel his tongue brush against his own, hot and wet and irresistable.

"I didn't know you drew me more than once, Steve," Bucky suddenly explained, mourning the loss of Steve's lips on his as he spoke but this was too important to be left unsaid. "I

only ever saw that one sketch and didn't look any further – I wasn't sure I could stand to have proof of you looking at me when I was convinced it didn't mean the same to you as it did to me."

"Oh, Buck," Steve scolded softly and kissed him again. "If I had known you'd felt the same, I would have shown you just how much I like to draw you." His tone was lower than Bucky had ever heard it as he rolled his hips upwards, making Bucky moan at the feeling of Steve hard and hot through the fine fabric of his trousers.

"I heard there's a bed somewhere around here?" Bucky mumbled against Steve's lips that curled into a smile. A surprised noise escaped him when Steve tightly gripped his thighs from below, pulling him closer as he stood up to carry Bucky. Steve pulled back slightly, his eyebrows raised with a questioning look but Bucky shook his head.

"Finish what you started, punk, and don't you dare drop me."

"Never, jerk," Steve replied before kissing Bucky again, hard and deep while pressing him into doorframe. With an impatient huff, Bucky tugged at Steve's shirt and revelled in the naked skin underneath. All of Steve felt so strong under Bucky's hand, his ribs, his chest, the firm muscles of his stomach, his jaw, and yet so soft, so warm, so much like home.

As soon as Steve made his way to his bedroom, Bucky hopped down, making them both chuckle as they almost tore their clothes off of each other. Unbuckled pants, shirts and underwear lay strewn across the floor in less than a minute and Bucky pushed Steve onto the bed, crawling over him to press their bodies against each other as they kissed hungrily. Steve's fingers trailed over Bucky's back, his legs, his torso, touching him everywhere without hesitation as if he couldn't get enough.

It was almost too much, to feel him everwhere and Bucky buried his face in the crook of Steve's neck, kissing and lightly biting him as he held back tears. Nothing he'd been doing with other people could have prepared him for how it felt to have Steve this close, Steve who knew him better than anything, Steve who had seen him in some of his worst moments, Steve who had apparently thought Bucky might have left.

"Hey, hey, you okay?" Steve asked gently because of course he could read Bucky like a book from the barely audible hitch in his breath to the urgency with which Bucky pressed himself on his chest. When he couldn't answer, too overwhelmed with how much he wanted this, how much he'd missed it before he'd ever experienced it, Steve went on: "Stay with me, Bucky, we're okay, we're here, we'll make this work. It's no longer illegal for us to be like this, no one's gonna judge us for it; no one who matters, anyways. Pretty sure Nat had us figured out for a while now, judging by what she had set up there today for us."

Bucky laughed wetly against Steve's collarbone because he knew Steve was right about Nat and about the rest as well and he could barely believe he could be this lucky.

“Guess we’ll have to thank her for more than just dinner, huh?” Bucky smiled and met Steve’s lips when he tilted in his direction. They kissed slowly with a heat that sent a thrill all over Bucky’s body and he let his fingers trail down Steve’s neck and chest, over both his nipples, down his sternum to his stomach and a little lower where a faint line of hair, several shades darker than the blond framing Steve’s beautiful face, started. Steve made a noise that sounded desperate and wanting and perfect, so Bucky let himself slide a little to the left, putting his weight in Steve’s arm who held him easily as he palmed lightly over Steve’s erection. The moan that elicited was something out of a dream and turned lower and a little hoarse when Bucky carefully thumbed over the head of Steve’s cock, precome slickening his fingers. He took his time as he started to stroke him, drinking in each and every gasp that fell from Steve’s lips. Then he groaned with surprise and pleasure as Steve moved his thigh to slot it in between Bucky’s legs, his hand on the small of Bucky’s back firm as he rocked them together, mirroring the pace Bucky set with his hand. Bucky had been hard for what felt like a delicious eternity and the gentle pressure of Steve’s thigh was just right to make him dizzy with it.

“Steve, I’m gonna…”

“Yeah, Buck, yes, yes-“

And then Steve’s body went tense under Bucky’s hand, his hips jerking helplessly as he came and the quiet, almost strangled sound from Steve sent Bucky right over the edge with him. He could feel himself fall for a second, panic threatening to coil around his limbs but Steve pulled him in, holding him so tightly Bucky instantly forgot what he was worried about.

They stayed like that for a while, Bucky watching the steady rise and fall of Steve’s chest while Steve carded through Bucky’s dark hair with those beautiful, long fingers of his.

“I think we need to get cleaned up,” Steve whispered almost apologetically at some point and so they did, sharing soft kisses under the hot shower, towelling each other off and deciding not to bother with clothes, instead just falling into bed together. Bucky stared at the ceiling when Steve turned to him and put his hand on his chest, right above Bucky’s heart.

“When you were gone and I started to believe you wouldn’t come back, I knew I could probably grow to love someone else. I’d need time, of course, but it seemed possible, despite everything. But I knew it’d be hard. Hard to open up to someone, hard to let someone in so deeply, hard to get *there*. And only then did it occur to me that it was never hard with you – you were the only person it felt easy to love. And you were gone.”

There was nothing Bucky could reply to that so he scooted a little closer and kissed Steve softly and slowly. He let his sorrow bleed into the way his lips clung onto Steve’s, let the ache wash over him one last time as he burrowed his hand in Steve’s hair.

Neither one of them said anything as they settled under the thin cover, tightly curled around each other. Bucky felt Steve's breath on his skin as Steve's eyes slipped shut and the little kick that went through Steve's body as he fell asleep.

There was a panic rising in the back of Bucky's mind, an urge to shake Steve awake, to not let him out of his sight ever again. But that was no way to live.

Maybe he'd wake up somewhere else, the next day or a week later or after ten years. But right now, he could have this and he wanted to savour every second of it. So Bucky inhaled deeply, the air smelling like Steve and sweat and sex and freshly washed sheets, relaxing his tense body in the warmth of Steve all around him and closed his eyes.